

The Test

Arora's "earnings" screenshot—which Google claims is doctored—is the first screenshot below. Then, we tested the script; it works like Arora claimed it would. (Second screenshot below.) Our account was disabled when Arora stopped sending out his e-mail invitations to click on his links.

To prove that he had full control, Arora started yet another account into which money is still flowing in. See on the previous page a slightly outdated screenshot of where the clicks are coming from. Make no mistake: this method—which involves a simple script and lots of connections to people—is powerful.

Naturally, we contacted Google and told them about how we had tested a certain click fraud script. Andrew Kovacs, a Google spokesman, got back and told us he'd like to speak with us. The only thing he asked us was, "When you ran the script, was it Manish Arora's?"

Clearly, *his is a name they're familiar with.*



The total number of invalid clicks we detect—whether for suspected malicious or non-malicious intent—is in the single digit percentages”

Shuman Ghosemajumder
Business Product Manager
for Trust And Safety
Google

The Actual Rate...?

Click fraud happens all the time—it's so easy. Some people quote it at a ridiculous high of 50 per cent; some say it is 10 per cent, some analysts quote figures in between. Shuman

	Page Impressions	Clicks	Page CTR	Page eCPM (12)	Earnings
AdSense for content	276,618	7,306	2.65%	\$18.29	\$5,059.58
AdSense for search	No data available				
Referrals	No data available				
Total Earnings	\$5,059.58				

A report of Arora's earnings as of 18 December 2006—his screenshot

	Page Impressions	Clicks	Page CTR	Page eCPM (7)	Earnings
AdSense for Content	5,151	199	3.86%	US\$4.80	US\$24.71
AdSense for Search - Get started					
Referrals - Get started					
Total Earnings	US\$24.71				

A report of our earnings in the AdSense account we used to try out Arora's method

Ghosemajumder, Business Product Manager for Trust And Safety at Google, says... well, there's a wee bit of controversy here. He has been quoted as saying that the click fraud rate is less than 2 per cent. But here's how he clarifies what he actually said, at shumans.com:

"... I never said that our click fraud rate is less than 2 per cent. Instead, what I said is that

the quantity of invalid clicks which we detect as a result of reactive investigations is a 'negligible proportion' of the total number of invalid clicks. Andy (Beal) asked me if that percentage is less than 2%. I told him that I was not able to provide a bound, but yes, 'negligible' certainly means less than 2% of invalid clicks.

"So what is our overall 'click fraud rate'? ... it is virtually impossible to know the intent of every click. However, we can do a very effective job using statistical techniques to detect potentially malicious behavior, and the total number of invalid clicks we detect—whether for suspected malicious or non-malicious intent—is in the single digit percentages."

(Andy Beal is a blogging and search engine marketing consultant. "Overall Click Fraud Rate" is commonly used to refer to the number of fraudulent clicks as a percentage of all clicks that happen, regardless of whether Google issues a refund or doesn't bill, according to Danny Sullivan of searchengineland.com.)

Kovacs informs us: "Less than 0.02% of clicks that are billed to the advertiser turn out to be fraudulent." That corroborates with a March 2007 claim by Google that less than 0.02% of all clicks slip past its filters and are caught after advertisers request reviews.

But there are plenty of things we can't get into here—including the idea that there are sceptics who don't like that figure. If you're interested, you should visit <http://tinyurl.com/yrh87l> for a detailed explanation by Sullivan.

But The Questions...

There are a lot of these, not entirely clear. Let's take a look at all of them.

Q. Why has Google said Arora is lying?

Proposed answer: We don't know. Arora could be lying. But then we tested his system ourselves and found that it works. Google categorically tells us it's "impossible" for Arora to have "earned" how much he did, but there's no explanation—while they *could* have given us one: Arora spelt out on his blog what he'd been doing.

Q. How can Digit be sure that Arora's system works?

A. We're referring to the fact that we "got" paid, as in, the money accrued in our AdSense account. However, would the clicks have been later detected as invalid and we wouldn't have been paid? We asked Kovacs about this, and there has been no response.

Q. Is Google taking Digit seriously?

A. We believe so. Kovacs has been our point of contact; he invited us to speak to Ghosemajumder about the issue. In one e-mail, he said our questions were "top priority."

Q. Is Google taking Arora seriously?

A. On the one hand, consider the alacrity with which Kovacs called us to ask if it was Arora's script we had been using. He said they had "dealt" with him before. On the other hand,